

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

System Administration

Saturday Night Special

TA quick and dirty hack written to save your weekend! These programs routinely break every rule in software development books but are still popular because of a simple reason - they work!

BOFH: Bastard Operator From Hell

The role model. Someone who will not stand acts of stupidity perpetrated by users on their servers. The steady state that every sys admin strives not to attain but invariably ends up in after a few months of administration.

MCSE: Must Consult Someone Experienced

Used to denote some of the rare situations when someone really experienced has to be called for help. Usually results in a few sleepless nights on mailing lists where ordinary mortals would not dare to venture.

Shebang

Probably the most frequently typed character-pair by a sysadmin, it stands for the "#!" typed at the beginning of every script to set the location of the interpreter/shell executable that has to run the script.

Snark

Refers to unexplained (hence suspicious) activity reported in system logs which if investigated properly could avert disastrous events such as a security breach.

Sanity Check

A "simple, routine" procedure undertaken to ensure that all is normal in server land, it includes a variety of scripts (off-the-shelf and homegrown) that report any suspicious activity to the concerned IT staff.

Playpens

A special environment in which the server is configured such that attackers and malicious users are first detected and then actively misled into believing that they are gaining a strong foothold into the system. In the mean time security-staff track them continuously to gain valuable forensic data.

The DVD Hollowcast

Once in a while, here at *Digit*, processes change hands, people are introduced into entirely new situations, and responsibilities. Why? Because it helps to build a stronger organisation, and gives our employees firsthand experience of varying processes, and newer, more uncomfortable places to sleep.

Raaabo (Robert Sovereign-Smith to the world) was given one such opportunity. He went from copy editing the magazine to content coordinating the DVD and CD. Sounds simple enough, right? Wrong! The only similarity was the thousands of little things he had to worry about? It went from thousands of words to thousands of MBs!

Somewhere along the way, he realised that the DVD needs to be sent for replica-

tion long before the magazine! Ouch! Shorter deadlines! Which obviously meant longer hours in the office? Caused mainly due to his bumbling about, and deleting the wrong folders in his sleep! We walked in a few mornings and found him sound asleep on his chair, and other mornings, he seemed to have disap-

peared...until we found him asleep under his desk. For over a week, his life revolved around his 4x4

foot workspace, and he finished the DVD just three days past his deadline!

So cheers to Raaabo! Hope he's got the hang of things, and finishes the DVDs on time from now on...mainly because none of us wants to tell his wife when she calls, "No, you can't speak to him because he's drooling over the carpet under his desk...sound asleep!"

DIGIT DIARY

an earlier moment in a live broadcast - courtesy: the hard drive.

Panasonic said the recorder offers high-speed dubbing from its hard drive onto DVD-RAM and DVD-R disks. It can record a 1-hour program onto a DVD-R disk in just 56 seconds, the company claims.

Connections include an Ethernet port and a broadband receiver. Use the Ethernet connection to view MPEG4 video and JPEG photos on a PC in another room. Using two such recorders, you can access MPEG2 video on one by the other via the LAN.

P2P SUES RIAA

Poetic Justice

For a change, a P2P company has sued the RIAA over a patent. Altnet, a subsidiary of Brilliant Digital Entertainment, says the RIAA infringed on one of its patents in the course of its efforts to enforce copyrights on P2P networks. Also named in the lawsuit are Overpeer, a copyright company, and MediaDefender.

Altnet has been looking

for funding sources and ways to strike back at the record labels' efforts to undermine P2P networks. In 2003, it announced that it purchased patent rights to the

process of identifying files on a P2P network using a hash, or digital fingerprints based on the file's contents.

Altnet's lawsuit centres on the fact that despite being notified several times in 2003 about the patent, RIAA executives continued to support Overpeer, and conducted their own enforcement procedures on the KaZaA network, thus infringing the patent.

Overpeer is a 'spoofing' company that posts millions of false or corrupted files on networks such as KaZaA, which makes real files hard to find. Media Defender uses 'interdiction' techniques, which clog networks with requests that block download efforts. Both these services use unauthorised versions of KaZaA and the underlying



FastTrack P2P technology. Altnet contends that this means they are using their patent without permission.

PRIME NUMBERS CRACKED?

A Disaster For All e-commerce?

September 7, 2004, *The Guardian* newspaper's headline screams: "Maths Holy Grail could bring disaster for Internet." That headline is as tabloidish as they get. But then, maybe not. It depends on whether Louis de Branges has really solved the Riemann hypothesis. If he has, "Financial disaster might follow. Suddenly all cryptic codes could be